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Ray Shiner

Multi-instrumentalist Ray Shiner was born on November 30, 1924 in Wilkes Barre, Pennsylvania and attended Eastman School of Music as a young man. His formal studies included first the violin, followed by bass and oboe in college, and later becoming accomplished on saxophone, English horn, piccolo and bass clarinet. His love of big bands led him to a memorable period in the 1950s with the Sauter-Finegan Big Band. Following this he freelanced in the New York City music scene, where he was an in-demand studio musician and symphony player. In 1967, Ray left the New York music scene for a position at SUNY Potsdam, teaching jazz and leading its jazz ensemble. He still maintains a relationship with some of his Potsdam students, and currently resides in the Syracuse area.

Ray was interviewed in Clinton, New York on August 11, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, and I'm very pleased to finally be able to meet with my good friend Ray Shiner, who is a multi-instrumentalist, educator and basically a source about many jazz folks including himself, so I'm finally glad to get the chance to talk to you.

RS: I'm glad to talk with someone who knows what he's talking about.

MR: Well we'll see if we can prove that today.

RS: We'll find out.

MR: When you were a young boy in Pennsylvania, was there a point in your teen years or even before where you said, I want to make a living as a musician? When did that happen for you?

RS: When I was six.

MR: Six. How come you knew so early?

RS: No I studied violin at a parochial school where the nun realized that I had some talent, so she arranged to have me excused from class one hour in the morning and one hour in the afternoon so I could go and practice.

MR: Wow.

RS: Of course I didn't know why, she never allowed me to use the piano to tune the violin, but I found out later it was because I had pitch recognition. But she started me on the road to thinking of being a musician, and it never left me.

MR: Did you stick with the violin for very long?

RS: No. Well I did up through college, but when I got to college I got to the Eastman School in Rochester, I studied oboe and bass fiddle.

RS: Well I heard the oboe teacher there and I said I don't need the violin anymore, I need the oboe.

MR: But why the bass fiddle too?

RS: Well I was a violin major, and because I had big paws, my violin teacher said, "You're never going to make it on the violin." He says, "You'll make it on bass." He says, "Take up bass." So I took up the bass.

MR: Well it's a good instrument too because it seems like they're always in demand.

RS: Oh I had a marvelous time playing bass and getting an instrument. I've been a very fortunate musician.

MR: Do you think playing the bass helped you as an overall musician because you're learning the foundations of the harmony and all that?

RS: With absolutely no doubt. I gravitate toward the lower instruments. I'm a good baritone sax player, I play good bass clarinet. I gravitate toward the bass instruments, because it's the root.

MR: How did your parents feel about your choice of career?

RS: They were in agreement, but I had polio as a youngster and it was a good thing to keep me occupied, keep me in the house practicing and listening to music, and I think I'm one of the luckiest people in life to be a musician all my life. I've earned a living playing, and I don't know too many people can say that.

MR: That's right. Most people who say they play a lot also have other sources of income.

RS: No, no. I was a player. I'm still a player.

MR: When you went to Eastman did you find any shock as far as the level of the other musicians there or were you pretty much right up there with them?

RS: No, no. I was shocked. I thought I was good until I got to Eastman.

MR: Right.

RS: Then I found out there's millions of good players in this country. But I did very well at Eastman, I was very fortunate.

MR: Now did they have any involvement in jazz at all at that time?

RS: It was unofficial. Jack End had a band. Jack was a clarinet teacher and he played in the Rochester Philharmonic, which eventually I played in, as an English horn and oboe player. Well I was alto sax soloist with the orchestra my first record date, which was very funny.

MR: What was the piece?

RS: "The Latin American Symphonette" by Morton Gould. And it was a duet between alto sax and oboe, my oboe teacher. That's 1951. And I never forgot it.

MR: That's neat.

MR: Well you obviously picked up a succession of instruments along the way. And your own personal taste in music eventually turned to swing—

RS: Jazz.

MR: And jazz. Can you recall the first listening experience with either of those with jazz that registered on you?

RS: Well it's hard to pin down except I remember specifically hearing Benny Goodman play "Benny Rides Again" a new arrangement by Eddie Sauter, when I was in high school. And when I got the call in Rochester from a woman who identified herself as from the Willard Alexander Agency, it was really Kay Finegan, Bill Finegan's wife, about auditioning for the Sauter-Finegan Orchestra, of course I was elated beyond expectation to hear that, because that's the greatest band that ever happened. And I started to rave about Eddie Sauter, didn't say a word about Finegan.

MR: You didn't know that you were talking to his wife.

RS: Well of course I had remembered "Benny Rides Again" from 1939, which Eddie wrote for Benny Goodman. And then when I auditioned for the band, I didn't believe it until I got to New York and saw who was there at the audition, that I was really auditioning for the Sauter-Finegan. Then when Eddie called me three days later and he says, "We'd like to have you on the band," I started to cry.

MR: And you left school to go do that?

RS: I was out of school by then.

MR: Oh you were, okay. And did you graduate with a teaching degree?

RS: I got a teaching degree because my oboe teacher said it would never hurt my playing.

MR: Oh. Well that's an astute comment. Right.

RS: Of course he was the solo oboist with the Rochester Philharmonic, and I was extra man with the Philharmonic. He says, "It never hurt me getting my job here," and he says, "it's not going to hurt you." Which, it really paid off, years later I called him up from New York, I says, "I've had it with this playing," I said, "get me a teaching gig." He says, "There's an opening at Potsdam."

MR: Oh no kidding. That's interesting that that connection, so many years later—

RS: Well he was teaching at Potsdam summers. He turned out to be one of my deepest, closest friends and deepest influence.

MR: Did you find playing classical music in an orchestra to be more or less stressful than playing jazz?

RS: More. More stressful.

MR: Can you elaborate on that? Because I tend to agree with you.

RS: Classical music is a drag.

RS: I mean I'm sticking my neck out except I just enjoy jazz so much more, there's more freedom and there's more interaction with other musicians, and you're listening — well you have to listen just as well in a classical situation, but I found in a jazz situation, it's really, it's a religion, it's a way of life, which is the way I expressed myself to my jazz band at Potsdam to the kids in the band. I said this is not a gig for me, this is a religion, this is a way of life. Of course I was vehement. I said if this can't be a way of life with you, you don't belong here.

MR: Well I've heard people describe it as an illness that you can't get rid of it.

RS: I don't care what you call it. I've been blessed.

MR: Did you ever have any difficult experiences with classical conductors?

RS: Oh yeah, many.

MR: Well name some. They're probably gone now.

RS: I had one, which I quoted, it was written up in the Rochester jazz paper, where they did dances from "West Side Story," which I premiered with the New York Philharmonic in New York. And the conductor, it was a birthday present for Lenny Bernstein. I won't name the conductor, but he stopped and he explained to me what jazz was. He's telling me what jazz was, and he's counting off twelve-eight time, which is the way symphony musicians play dotted eighth and sixteenths.

MR: Oh, right, oh I see.

RS: You know [scats]. They play it like that, and I go [scats] which is the way you're supposed to play it. So after about three tries and encouragement from the guys in the orchestra — I was going to say guys in the band — the guys in the New York Philharmonic, friends of mine, they said, "Give it to him Ray, don't take that from him." Of course that set me off because I said I don't need this from him. I said, "You want it the way it's written? The way you're singing it? Or the way it should be played?"

MR: All right.

RS: So that kind of stopped the conversation. And the guy accompanying me on that bit was the marimba player, who was an original member of the Sauter-Finegan band, Walter Rosenberger. So Walter played the marimba and I played the alto sax and that was it. Bernstein came in a month later to record it. And he just said, "Is my sax player here?" And I says, "Yeah, right here." "Is my trumpet player here?" And Gino says, "He's here." So we were the two outside men from the New York Philharmonic.

MR: Okay. There you go.

RS: So we did two fast takes, and nobody said a word. I don't know if that explains it.

MR: Yeah, sure it does.

RS: It takes up time.

MR: It's interesting the way you described the way classical musicians think of the swing eighth rhythm too, with the twelve-eight thing. They think of it as a triplet with the first note longer and the second note shorter.

RS: Yeah. Which is wrong.

MR: Which is wrong. But it's as close as — they need to try to put it in a context that they can understand it. So it's as close as they can get it I guess. So you did the [scats].

RS: That's right. That's at the beginning of the piece.

MR: Right.

RS: Well anyway.

MR: Neat. No I like that story.

RS: It's part of my life. I played alto sax with the Rochester Philharmonic, the Chicago Orchestra, the New York Philharmonic, I'm a sax player.

MR: Well listen, how did your name come up when they started to put the Sauter-Finegan band together?

RS: They were auditioning musicians in New York when they started the band, and they said, "Does anybody know of any oboe doublers?" And this one trombone player said, "Yeah I know a guy up in Rochester." Eddie Irwin, Eddie played in the New York Philharmonic. He says, "This guy doubles, he's a good doubler." He says, "I don't call him a doubler, he plays good oboe." So I didn't know it was through Ed that I got the audition until I got to the rehearsal, to the audition itself, which was a combination audition-rehearsal, and I saw Ed in the trombone section and Jim Buffington, a French horn player was there. Everybody in town knew I was coming to town to audition, so they all showed up at the audition.

MR: Oh, that's nice.

RS: Which was a nice feeling.

MR: What did the audition consist of? Just playing some of their charts?

RS: Just sitting in and playing the charts. And one number they played was "Moonlight on the Ganges," and I missed every note. I was so nervous, it was so difficult. And then six months later, after I been on the band, I never figured out how I got on the band, I says to Finegan, "How come you picked me to play oboe in the band?" I says, "I missed every note on 'Ganges.'" He said, "You played two good bars on 'When Hearts Are Young.'" And he says, "And the guys in the band wanted you." So, which was another thing — that was a very unusual band. We were all, it was like a family. Two players in the band said, "We want Shiner." That was it.

MR: It's nice to have that support, yeah. Was there any talk about, was this a good idea to be trying to be forming a big band now, was it what, '52?

MR: Okay. That the big band era—

RS: Was going out then.

MR: Yeah. These guys wanted to do it anyway.

RS: Yeah. They had the wrong booking agent, Willard Alexander, who was used to booking dance bands, and we were not a dance band, we were a concert band for listening. You could dance to us, because Eddie and Bill wrote arrangements which were conducive to dancing, but it was very puzzling to the audience because the melody used to shift from one section to the next or a different combination of instruments. We'd get to a gig and the people would yell up to the bandstand, "Why don't you play something we can dance to?" And Sonny Russo, my roommate on the band would yell down, "Why don't you dance to something we can play to?" It was a very funny band too. We all had a great sense of humor and we had a hundred percent backing from the leaders.

MR: Yeah? Did they play with the band also?

RS: Well Eddie loved to — he was a frustrated percussion player. And Finegan just directed, well he was a great piano player. They were both consummate musicians and we adored them. Every night after the gig we'd walk up to them and apologize for the mistakes we made in the arrangements.

MR: So what would a tour at that time consist of for you? Was it playing colleges or dance halls?

RS: It was playing a lot of colleges. Originally we played every dance hall in the eastern circuit, which was a certain death. You know, people, they didn't understand our band or know what we were playing, didn't know what we were doing or they could care even less.

MR: I'm trying to place the pop music that was going on in the early '50s too. It wasn't quite rock & roll yet.

RS: Well they confused us with Ralph Flanagan, that's probably the biggest insult you could give us because Ralph Flanagan to us was the lowest. But some idiot at RCA confused the name Flanagan with Finegan.

MR: Oh God.

RS: And stuck with it, and insisted Ralph Flanagan was the band, because he thought it was Bill Finegan. He had the names confused.

MR: So he was promoting the group as a sound that didn't exist.

RS: Yeah.

MR: Wow.

RS: And of course we started out with 42 numbers in the library, but every time the band — we all had different backgrounds. Some of us had strictly classical backgrounds, some

both, and some jazz backgrounds. We had great jazz musicians in the band. And we used to fake, well we'd play medleys, fake medleys.

MR: To get through the gig.

RS: To get through the gig. It was probably that — you start me talking and I won't stop, it's the happiest days of my life.

MR: That's okay. That's why we're here. I mean can you tell me what you were making on that band?

RS: I started making a hundred and a quarter. I got a raise to a hundred and fifty. That was a lot of money.

MR: Yeah, sure.

RS: I didn't care if it paid ten cents. I was a member of — I still brag about it today, I was a member of the original Sauter-Finegan Orchestra. And I don't care about the money. None of us did. We had world famous jazz musicians. Mundell Lowe played guitar, Nick Travis played trumpet, Joe Ferrante played trumpet, Sonny Russo played — you know we had great musicians on that band.

MR: And what label did you record on?

RS: RCA. But toward the end we recorded for United Artists — UA.

MR: When you went in to do a recording session, how long did you usually get in the studio to do a record?

RS: Usually, I don't know, you were supposed to do three or four numbers in three hours. Sometimes we'd do five or six and we'd be sight reading.

MR: You'd be sight reading.

RS: There was one number we did, the A & R man came on and he says, "Okay, let's do another one." Finegan says, "No, we're not doing another one." He says, "Why not?" He says, "The guys in the band don't want to do another one, they like that one." He says, "There's a couple of mistakes." Finegan says, "The hell with the mistakes, the feel was there." And of course we had our revenge. RCA wanted us to do something with kazoos because that was the rage. So Finegan, something that Bob Merrill wrote, he's the guy that wrote "Take Me Along" for Jackie Gleason, because he was a pop composer. So Finegan wrote "Sunshine Girl," which was the name of the tune, for 21 kazoos, with jazz kazoo, played by Sonny Russo and Nick Travis.

MR: Did you record it?

RS: Oh we recorded it. One of the biggest hits we ever made. Strictly a put on, right? I could tell you stories about that band.

MR: Well tell me stories about the band.

RS: No, no. We played out in Hollywood on the "Show of Shows." It was an hour and a half

Ganges," the number that almost killed my career in music when I auditioned for the band. But they came out and they put a turban on me so I looked like a Hindu, and they put a turban on Eddie Sauter and Eddie's conducting, and at the rehearsal they had a string tied to an overhead teaser and on the bottom of the string was a fake snake, and when I played "Ganges" somebody would wiggle the string and you'd see the fake snake going like this. This was live television, 1954. So come the show, somebody untied the string and they're weaving this string, or they thought they untied the string but they didn't. It was still tied to my music stand and they started wiggling this snake in front of me, and a stage hand started pulling up the scenery, and my music stand went up and I thought I was sinking and I'm playing oboe like this, the string broke, the music came down and knocked over instruments. This was coast to coast television. Anyway.

MR: That's a good one.

RS: That's just one of the many stories that we had.

MR: Did you guys have practical jokers in the band?

RS: Oh yeah. We had 21 musicians on the band, and 21 practical jokers. Nineteen musicians and two leaders.

MR: What was the worst thing that you ever pulled, can you recall?

RS: Oh it's hard to describe. I can't describe that one.

MR: Well how about the second worst?

RS: Well the second worst was I stood up to play a tenor sax solo on "Manhattan," it was written for me, a special arrangement, I had dear friends in the audience waiting to hear every note, and it was at a public dance, and they had balloons there, and as soon as I stood up to play the tenor sax solo, somebody started putting pins, popping balloons, which killed it.

MR: Right, I guess. How did the band — did it struggle to stay alive from a financial standpoint?

RS: Yeah. Well it got so bad at one point where the leaders took twenty-five dollars apiece for themselves just to be able to pay the guys in the band. And we didn't want that. So the band folded. We did just weekends. I left the band, I had left the band, a lot of guys had left the band, and the band did a couple of weekends and that was it. We lost $90,000 in the '50s, that was a lot of money then.

MR: Sure.

RS: And the bill fell on Eddie to pay off, and Finegan.

MR: One of them finally went to Europe, right?

RS: Eddie went to Europe to conduct the Baden Baden, West German Jazz Band. He took a couple of guys from the band with him, including the harpist Blanche Birdsong went and

Sperry Kassman went in percussion and Dave Hildinger went on percussion and piano. And the bass player went.

MR: And Finegan went west?

RS: Finegan stayed where he was. Scuffled in New York.

MR: Yeah. So in your tenure in that band you played oboe and tenor sax—

RS: English horn.

MR: English horn.

RS: Flute, piccolo, clarinet, and Nick Travis used to travel with the bass player and if a car got stuck on the road I'd wind up playing bass with the band. What an experience.

MR: Well you were a good guy to have around.

RS: Well I felt great being on that band. It was a privilege. I'm the luckiest man in the world that I was a performing musician on that band.

MR: So after that, what five years, four or five years—

RS: Four or five years. Well it goes beyond that because after the band broke up we recorded in '57 and '59 and '61 and '65. And I made most of the records with the band. One album I didn't make. One album I did half of it, but the last day was done by my replacement so he got his name on the album. I don't care about that, I know I was there.

MR: You knew you were there. Do you still listen to those records?

RS: Once in a while. Once in a while. I'm surprised they play it on the radio. About three months ago they had a forty hour retrospective on Eddie Sauter and they played everything he ever wrote for the band in New York City. And a friend of mine recorded the whole thing and sent me tapes of the whole show, complete with stories.

MR: Now when did you get married?

RS: 1956.

MR: So that was during that, or was that just about—

RS: No that was after.

MR: That was after you got out.

RS: That was immediately after. I had left the band and I took a Broadway show. My wife was an assistant choreographer and we went to Boston and she liked Lebanese food so the arranger was Hershey Kay and Hershey says, "Do you care if I bring a chick?" I says no. So he brought Dorothy. Shorty I called her. She was the assistant choreographer. He brought her to the restaurant and she ate everything I ordered. I says that's the girl for me.

MR: How romantic.

RS: No I was the luckiest man. She's the most wonderful thing that ever happened to me. And our daughter Kristen is the most wonderful that ever happened to us. So I'm blessed all the way around, as a musician and as a person, I can't complain.

RS: In Syracuse.

MR: In Syracuse. Eventually you made the move to New York City — I'm talking okay, so I'm talking what, 40— I'm sorry, 60—

RS: '67 I moved to Potsdam to teach.

MR: Okay. But I want to talk about New York City a little more if you don't mind.

RS: Sure. I love New York City. My favorite restaurants.

MR: As a free lance musician, what's the best way for you to — I'm talking in general — get your reputation out there?

RS: I was lucky I had a reputation before I got to New York. I had a reputation from the Sauter-Finegan Orchestra from the '50s. I was in New York in '48 but that was sporadically. I didn't settle in New York until '53, and that was with the Sauter-Finegan Orchestra. And my name had gotten around from playing with that band, although I had played with other bands, well I played with Ray McKinley's band after that. I played with Tito Puente, Tito Rodriguez, Sonny Dunham, a bunch of bands. Some — I only remember one, the Sauter-Finegan Orchestra.

MR: Was the recording scene pretty healthy in the '50s once you got out and started to get into studio work?

RS: It was pretty steady at that particular time, but I had gotten to know some other people, Norm and Jimmy Leyden, and then I was doing a lot of jingles, which is not the greatest musically, but monetarily it sustained me. When I got married I made sixty dollars a week doing two television shows with Norman Leyden. Thirty a week for each television show. But that was a lifesaver. Norm and Jimmy kept me going there for many years.

MR: Well you told me earlier that your first apartment in New York cost—

RS: Seventeen dollars and fifty cents.

MR: A month?

RS: A month.

MR: Wow.

RS: My second apartment cost seventy dollars a month. And my third apartment cost eighty-five dollars a month. When I left New York it was two hundred and eighty-five dollars a month, but I don't complain one bit.

MR: Well tell me about working studio dates. You would get a call to come and they would specify what they wanted you to play, but you didn't really know what the music was going to be.

RS: Didn't know anything until I got there.

MR: And then you'd read it down.

RS: Sight read it. That was the reputation you had to have before they'd call you to play a studio date. If you didn't make it, the news would get around town that this guy bombs, and you wouldn't get called again.

MR: Yeah that's tough.

RS: So each date was an audition. I was lucky. The musicians are very nice, and they're very thoughtful and they're very helpful. They would break their neck to help you. We had one date, I have to tell you this, the A&R man usually from the advertising agency, and a lot of times they imagine that they're musicians. This guy thought he was a musician and he yelled in — we had five saxes there, we were all playing flute. We were playing unison flute, you know what unison flute is?

MR: Yeah.

RS: We're all playing the same notes. This guy had to show that he knew something about music, so he hit the intercom button he says, "All right guys," he says, "we've got to straighten something out." He says, "The third flute there's a couple of bad notes at Letter C." We're all playing unison, the same note. So I look at Phil, and he looks at me, and we both looked at Romeo, and these are the most famous doublers in New York City.

MR: This is Romeo Penque?

RS: Romeo Penque and Phil Bodner.

MR: And Phil Bodner.

RS: Now you don't go any higher than that. And the three of us are looking at each other, and he said, "What kind of an idiot do we have in the control room?" Of course I don't say this. Phil was the diplomat among the three of us. He says, "Let me handle it." He says, "Give us a couple of minutes and we'll straighten it out." So he looks at me and he looks at Romeo and he says, [whispers] "Play the same notes." So we played the same notes and the guy in the control room says, "That's better." So we took twenty minutes to do this, and we got twenty minutes overtime.

MR: That's a good one.

RS: I can tell these stories now.

MR: Well, I like to hear them.

RS: Well this is a long time ago.

MR: Can you recall a session that was particularly memorable either because it was really difficult and that you barely made it through it, or because it was so utterly ridiculous, like the story you just told me, music-wise maybe it was like really silly?

RS: Well there were a lot of silly dates, but I don't think about those. I think about the hard ones, the ones where I just about made, and the ones where I may have made a mistake and wasn't too proud of it. But there was one date we did, the opening — I shouldn't tell

around and they were setting up the mics for balance. I played a couple of wrong notes in the intro. I didn't know it until the record came out. But of course you couldn't hear it unless you separated the channels and listened very carefully. I was personally embarrassed. I've never told this story. But there's a couple of wrong notes I played on it.

MR: Well, when you look at your career as a whole, I think a couple of wrong notes, we can live with that.

RS: I'm starting to live with it now.

MR: I take it you were a perfectionist.

RS: Yeah, that's part of my undoing. I was a perfectionist, my wife was a perfectionist, and some of it has rubbed off on my daughter except we took pains to let her know that she doesn't have to do everything perfectly. And she's done very well. She's a published composer, she plays all the percussion instruments, she loves to play piano for fun, and her favorite thing is to sing. But I'm very proud of Kristen, so is her mother.

MR: Yeah. And she is a good drummer.

RS: She's a great drummer. When Clark Terry — of course my ambition when I moved to Syracuse, I said to my wife, I says, "I'm going to get Clark to play with me in Syracuse." And it took a few years. Finally I called Clark up and I said, "I want you to play with the band." He says, "Okay, when?" And he was very sick with diabetes. He got off the plane in a wheelchair, and we brought him to the Civic Center in Syracuse where he played with us, with the Central New York Jazz Band. And he absolutely killed the crowd. Of course he called Kristen to come up in front of the audience to sit in with us to play drums. He says, "We dedicate this one to Shorty," that's my wife. And of course I started to cry.

MR: Yeah. That was a great event. You guys did a good thing there with that orchestra.

RS: We had a good time. And the guys in the band killed me though. Krissy sat in and she starts on the hi-hat [scats]. And the guys in the band would come in, and he says, "Why can't she play with us?" — which was not really a compliment, but she did a nice job. I wanted her to play because the concert before, Rob McConnell was our soloist, from the Boss Brass, and he had one arrangement on an old record of his that I loved, "Every Time We Say Goodbye" — I says, "Hey I want to do 'Every Time We Say Goodbye.'" He says, "Oh that's old stuff, we don't do that anymore. So this was in September — November rather. And come Christmas he said — he called me up on the phone and he says, "You've got a package in the mail coming, look for it." He found the score to "Every Time We Say Goodbye" and he sent it to me. Woof. So I had, Cal Custer was our pianist, and he was an ace computer man, and he took it off and copied the parts off in computer and had a vibes part, and I called Krissy up, my daughter, and I says, "You're

playing vibes on my next concert. Anyway, I'm waxing nostalgically here, but I've had a wonderful time in music.

MR: Was there a place that you musicians hung out in New York waiting for calls and so forth?

RS: Yeah. Well there were several places. We hung out at Joe Harbor's Spotlight Cafe, or Juniors, or the Confucius Chinese Restaurant. Of course the Band Box was there at that time and Basin Street was there, and Lester Young was still functioning and so was Billie Holiday, so was Benny Carter, you know a lot of great, famous musicians, Jack Teagarden. This is going back quite a few years.

MR: What's this place Jim & Andy's bar?

RS: Jim & Andy's was where all the musicians hung out. Jim Koulouvaris was the owner of the bar. Jim used to loan money to any musician in town that needed it. His pay phone was the hangout for every musician in town. The phone rang one day, and of course whoever was closest to the phone would answer it. I answered the phone, I says hello. "Is Nick Travis there?" I says, "Yeah, just a minute." I said, "Hey Nick, it's for you." Nick went to the phone and he picked it up and he says, "Yeah this is Nick." And the voice at the other end says, "Nick, this is Zoot." And Nick says, "Zoot who?" That's the kind of a place we hung out at. This was at 48th Street, this is down in the basement. Up on the sixth floor was the A&R Studios, run by Phil Ramone, who is a famous A&R man today. He's Barbra Streisand's A&R man or something. He was just another genius in those days.

MR: So people would call down there—

RS: People would call down there and say, "We need a sax player" or, "we need a trombone player," "we need a trumpet player." Whatever they needed. Willie Rodriguez used to hang out there, a lot of great musicians used to hang out at Jim & Andy's.

MR: And all this stuff was tied in to the union too, right?

RS: Loosely.

MR: Loosely. Okay.

RS: The union was there because we had to belong to the union.

MR: Yeah. And so when you went to do a date—

RS: Of course the union collected all the money, because we had to hand in contracts, and they had to be approved by the union.

MR: And then you had to go to the union office to get your pay, is that right?

RS: Yes. I'd get in line, they had a recording line, people who would direct the dates, you'd go up to the date and you'd tell Julie your name, and he'd look on the list and say, "You've got three checks" or, "you don't have any checks today." You know, so he

MR: What did it cost to belong to the local in the early 50s? Do you recall?

RS: I think it cost $52 for an initiation fee, maybe $25 a year dues. It's much more than that now.

MR: And you had, was there like a six month period or something—

RS: I had a six month period and I had to transfer, I transferred from the Rochester local which was my home local. It took six months. And you could do casuals, you could single dates, which I did, and that sustained me while I was waiting for the 802. And then when I got the 802, the New York Union Card, then I could take a steady job. And then I took a steady job that paid $85 a week, which was nothing. I did the original "Three Penny Opera" down in the Villages with Lottie Lenya and Bea Arthur. Oh you should have seen who was on the cast. Leon Janney, some famous people, Jerry Stiller from Stiller & Meara, and Jerry Orbach was in the show, and Bea Arthur. Some really famous names on Broadway. That was their first gig. We all did "Three Penny Opera" for scale. I have to tell you a funny thing that happened. Charlie Russo was the other sax player and we were in full view of the audience and I played tenor sax and clarinet. And at one point there was a tenor sax solo in the dark. And I played the solo. And in the middle of the solo I let out a squeak that you wouldn't believe, unintentionally naturally. And the lights went on and my face was red, and Charlie Russo reaches in his pocket, in full view of the audience, and puts a band-aid on my stand and says, "Are you okay?" So you know, a sense a humor sustains you.

MR: I would say it has to. Who were some of your most favorite fellow musicians that you associated with?

RS: Well I would start off by saying the guys in the Sauter-Finegan band. Any guy in that band, dear friends, cohorts. Gene Allen played baritone, Wally Kane, Al Bach, Harvey Estin, that's the reed section, Sonny Russo — I could go through the whole band. Joe Ferrante, Nick Travis, Bobby Nichols, Tommy Mitchell. The whole list, the whole Sauter-Finegan band. But there were a lot of New York musicians, Clark Terry, Milt Hinton, Joe [inaudible], Sol Gubin, Urbie Green — Urbie was soloist in the Sauter-Finegan band on a couple of numbers we did. Urbie was a very dear friend.

MR: What was the racial atmosphere during your tenure in New York as far as the studio work, and playing in clubs and that kind of thing?

RS: Black musicians had a hard time, like they still do, except today not so much. But my closest friends were black musicians. The biggest compliment that I've ever had was they considered me black. When Shorty, my wife, died, the Basie Band played in town, and Frank Foster is a dear friend of mine, and I know every guy in the band. My first date with Shorty where I took her to hear Basie, she said, "What are you taking me to hear

MR: You've got to get their approval.

RS: Sure. Which was the truth. This is 38 years later, you know, Frank Foster he says, "Where's Shorty?" I says, "She died last year." This was in Syracuse. So at intermission he went out and he announced, he said, "We'll dedicate this concert to Ray Shiner and his wife Shorty." He says, "Ray, this number is for Shorty." And they went into "L'il Darlin'" and I cried for twenty minutes. That's what they thought of me and my wife. They treated me as one of theirs. So I'm very partial, and very blessed. When Clark Terry heard about Shorty, of course he called up when she was sick, and he spoke with her on the phone and I said, "She can't talk" and she answered him with one word answers on the telephone. And when Clark was here playing at the festival in October, he had the college send a limo to Syracuse to pick me up and bring me here, to sit with his family, to hear the concert, to feed me lunch and to take me back to Syracuse. Clark Terry did that for me, because I'm one of the family, and so is my wife Shorty.

MR: Well I think it's interesting that the guys that rise to the top are also the nicest guys.

RS: They are. They are. I feel blessed. I feel doubly blessed knowing all the people. At one time I thought of moving to Hamilton I was so happy here. Because everybody at Hamilton has treated me so wonderfully, everybody. I won't mention names because I'm afraid I'll miss somebody.

MR: Well that's good to hear. Eventually you decided to get out of the New York scene. Was it New York or was it the music scene, really, or was it a combination?

RS: A combination. My daughter was eight going towards nine at the time, and I said, "Krissy keeps complaining that she has to yell up at me where we live to come down and get her" because it wasn't safe I guess. Well I was a typical Lebanese father. I'm very protective of my children, or my child. I said, "Enough of this, we have to take a cab to go to Brooklyn to go to the dentist, we have to take a cab uptown and I don't want to get in the subway. It's time we went to a small town. So I went to Potsdam. Not to put New York down, New York is still the greatest city in the world. It's not the same today. If it were possible, but every time a band came to Potsdam or to Syracuse or Watertown or any place near us, and Shorty and I would go to hear the band, she'd say, "I expect you to get on the bus to go off with the band." It was usually the Basie Band, and the guys would say, "Shiner, you're late, get on the bus." She says, "I wouldn't be surprised if you got on the bus.

MR: Why did you have such a close association with the Basie Band?

RS: It was always my favorite band. It was the Sauter-Finegan favorite band. We had a night off in Wichita and we all conned Joe Gray, our bus driver, to take us to hear Count Basie. The whole Sauter-Finegan band went to hear Count Basie. No, that was our favorite

MR: Do you like what's happened with the band since the Count passed on?

RS: They've kept the tradition. They've played a few new things here and there, but they play a lot of the old things. Frank Foster had the band for a time, Grover Mitchell has the band now I think. Freddie Green, the guitar player, had the band for a while.

MR: Oh I didn't know that.

RS: Yeah.

MR: He doesn't seem like the leader type, but you never know—

RS: No. Freddie's not the leader type, but he was. The guys in the band respected him.

MR: And Thad Jones too.

RS: Thad Jones was the leader of the band. I hate to forget names, but just people I associate with. Something humorous to me personally was when Freddie Green had the band and at intermission I went up to Freddie and I says, "Freddie, I want you to meet Mike Scott." I says, "I've got three of them in the band" meaning three brothers. They are three black cats I had in the band. And Freddie thought I meant I had three black cats in the band, and that I was trying to be—

MR: Oh, trying to be hip.

RS: Trying to be hip. And I got a look from him that I don't believe. I saw Clark Terry two weeks later and I says, "How well do you know Freddie Green?" He says, "Very well." I says, "Will you go to Freddie and explain to him who the hell I am and what I meant by that remark?" I told him what I had said and Freddie's reaction. I said, "I was never so embarrassed in my life." Anyway—

MR: I'll bet Clark got a kick out of it.

RS: Oh yeah.

MR: How did you adapt to life in small town Potsdam?

RS: Very difficult. No, I've loved my oboe students and I adored my jazz band, the guys in my band. Because this was, gee that's 1967, this is 1999, '98, this is thirty years later, I'm still in touch with them by telephone or by mail, of guys in my band. It's still my band. And they treat me like I'm still their leader. It's a family. But that's as a result of my being on the Sauter-Finegan band because the Sauter-Finegan band is still the same band and we're still members of the same family. And if you're a member of Shiner's band, you're still a member of his band.

MR: Did the college music department support the jazz—

RS: No. They did to a certain extent. I shouldn't talk about Potsdam like that, but they had their shortcomings.

MR: Well you know jazz education was not even hardly a term then, right?

RS: My band, after the second year, was invited to play the national MENC, Music

said no it would be bad for the name of the college to have jazz associated with Potsdam. And the leader of the wind ensemble was invited to play in Washington and he called me up and he says, "Ray," he says, "I arranged it so you wouldn't get noise from the front office." He says, "Every guy in your band is in the wind ensemble, so they can't give you any noise about transporting them to Washington." So I told them this fact, it didn't phase them one bit. So I gave up the band for a couple of years, but then I says I can't do this. But I don't put Potsdam away, they gave me a lot of encouragement. One year, of course I've been a radical all my life as you may have gathered by now. But one year they had a new auditorium up there where the reverb was six seconds or something like that. If you played something, six seconds later you'd hear it played back. I refused to play a concert in Hosner Hall. I says, "No, I don't play there." "Where will you play?" I says, "College Theater." Well you can't play there, nobody plays there." I says, "I play there." "Well you know you can't do that." I says, "Well then cancel the concert" which is kind of nervy. The guy looked at me and he says, "You've got to go through me to play the concert" he says, "Are you canceling?" I says, "Yeah, tell the dean I'm canceling the concert." So he went to the dean and he says, "Shiner says he's canceling the concert." He says, "Well what's the matter?" He says, "He wants to play College Theater." He says, "Give him the College Theater."

MR: I know what you're saying, some of those auditoriums are not built for those kind of things.

RS: No. Anyway, I got the College Theater and of course I have close contact with the College Theater, all the people on the stage crew, the head of the drama department, they're all friends of mine, because I like art. I appreciate the finer things in life, and my wife and I supported them so they supported me. That, I don't know if that has any relationship to what you want to hear, so.

MR: You turned out, you had some students that went on to become pretty well known.

RS: Pretty big.

MR: Was it Renee Fleming?

RS: Renee Fleming is a world famous vocal soloist at the Met. She sang with my band, her first gig singing. No, no she sang in beer joints in Potsdam, but singing with a band, she sang with my band.

MR: Interesting.

RS: Glenn Drews, Gary Keller, Gary Burke, Bruce Petrucci — a lot of well known musicians. Mike DiMeo.

MR: What made you come to Syracuse after that?

RS: Joe Corello.

RS: I says, "Joey, I'm retiring." He says, "Come to Syracuse, I'll get you a band." He knew that was the first thing in my life.

MR: Right.

RS: He says, and he says, "My old man, my father will get you a house and get a big enough yard for Shorty to have a garden," he says, "so you've got it made." So he did that. And my first year, Shorty had her garden and I had my band.

MR: And you were playing — I know I've seen you out on gigs playing bass and different things.

RS: Yeah, I've had a good time in Syracuse. I'm a Syracusan as far as they're concerned, even though I have home roots in Rochester. I have a brother and a sister, and I have nieces and nephews and friends, and my daughter and son-in-law in Rochester.

MR: Do you have an opinion about the state of jazz today?

RS: It's in decay. It's pop and rock. Not even pop, it's rock & roll. It's not even rock & roll it's — I don't know what you call it because I don't listen to it. It's sickening. It's noise. Noise is the way I describe it. But of course I'm an old reprobate.

MR: What about fellows like Warren Vache, Scott Hamilton?

RS: Oh they're great players. No, no, no, those are great players. I love Dixieland. You know you have Dixieland, you have traditional music, you have some of the greatest jazz musicians in the world play here at Hamilton. You know, Warren Vache, you have Kenny Davern, you have, name them, Ralph Sutton.

MR: Yeah. So it's still happening but it's an awful small—

RS: You've got Joe Wilder here. You had Clark Terry here, which is what brought me here, you had Milt Hinton, which is what brought me here.

MR: We had Frank Foster here.

RS: You had Frank Foster here. These are all dear friends of mine. You had Bobby Rosengarden. I worked with him when he was with ABC, he was the musical director for Dick Cavett. I had a great life in New York and these guys have never forgotten me and I've never forgotten them.

MR: Well that is a good story. Your life's a good story.

RS: Well I've been very fortunate and blessed. I got to meet you, I'm not trying to throw bouquets at you, but you know what I'm talking about, I don't have to draw a picture for you.

MR: If there is one part of your life that you could have sustained longer, would it have been the Sauter-Finegan band?

RS: Yeah. Notice how long it took me answer that.

MR: Notice I didn't even have to ask the question.

MR: Of course.

RS: Because she'd grin a mile wide hearing me talk like this. And we were both so proud of our daughter Krissy. We've been blessed.

MR: Well it's great that you have documentation of that period of your life.

RS: Well it's something I can't forget, don't want to forget, and I'm lucky to have known.

MR: I'm curious, you know there's now with so many cable channels they have the T.V. Land station and they have these, they call them retro commercials, they're showing some of the old commercials. I'm wondering if you ever hear yourself?

RS: Well I'll tell you what I will see is probably my wife dancing. She did one of the first Stopette commercials, just a dialogue, no music, just talk.

MR: For which?

RS: Stopette. The original — see you're young — it's an original deodorant. Stopette was one of the original deodorants.

MR: I'll be darned.

RS: Dorothy Jarnac was her professional name, and she would come out and the announcer would go through this copy and she would do the copy by walking. She was on the Peter Lind Hayes Show. She was on many shows. She was on concert stage.

MR: Wouldn't that be something to see that.

RS: Oh, I wish they had videos of my wife dancing. Well she was in a movie. She did "Lili" she was the barn puppet in the movie "Lili," and she was in several Broadway shows, the Bluerville brought her to New York. She did "Ticket Squeeze," oh she was a world famous dancer. She was in *Life* Magazine twice.

MR: Well it's no wonder you two were attracted to each other, being into art and Lebanese food.

RS: The Lebanese food, which is what did it, which kills me. I'm Lebanese and my wife was a mixture of Irish, German, English, Spanish, a little French, everything. But she liked Lebanese food.

MR: I neglected to ask you about your own parents.

RS: My own parents?

MR: Did they come here from—

RS: They were here, their parents came from Lebanon and of course they came from a small town named Hardine, which no one ever heard of, until I got to Syracuse. I met a doctor who treated my wife when she was getting evaluated for cancer. Of course she was just getting evaluated at the time. And he said, "Oh yeah," he says, "I've heard of Hardine," he says, "I've been there." He says, "Your wife's not Lebanese," he says, "you are" he says, "I hear you speak the language." I says, "I only know the names of the food" I says,

"I don't speak the language." He says, "Well you mentioned that in one word" he says, "you're from Hardine," he says, "they're the only people that pronounce it that way.

MR: Well it's really been fascinating talking to you.

RS: It's been enjoyable talking with you. I got to talk about things that are important to me.

MR: And I know we'll be seeing you here at Fallcoming.

RS: Oh yeah. I never miss coming here. This is — I've often thought of moving to Hamilton, or moving to Clinton. It's just overwhelmingly physically difficult to move.

MR: Yeah, right.

RS: I have tapes, records, cassettes, hi-fi systems, instruments, a Steinway piano, I have everything. It's overwhelming just thinking about moving. I have original Sauter-Finegan tapes, when we did the Camel Caravan with the — if you'll pardon the expression — Vaughan Monroe.

MR: These were live?

RS: Live.

MR: Yeah.

RS: Live shows. Oh I've been very lucky. I've had a wonderful life.

MR: Well it sounds like a good place for us to wrap up.

RS: Yeah. Thank you for asking me. I'm flattered.

MR: It's been my pleasure.

RS: And I'm happy to be here.

MR: All right. Thank you.

RS: Thank you Luis.